What went wrong with Operation Blue Star? Basically, the army is not meant to conduct such an operation. Under normal circumstances, it was a job meant for the police and paramilitary forces. But these were not used when they could have completed the task with far less loss of life and property. By June 1984, the situation was much beyond their capacity to handle.

As far as the actual operation was concerned, it was the case of a highly ambitious and proud General K. Sundarji nursing dreams of becoming a field marshal, trying to finish his job in a jiffy to please Indira Gandhi. In the process, he underestimated the capabilities, commitment and religious fervour of an equally proud group of Jat Sikhs, well equipped and trained by a professional and battle-hardened general, willing to sacrifice their lives to defend the Harmandir Sahib complex.

Being too proud to admit that the faulty planning and execution resulted from their over-confidence, Sundarji and his juniors later tried to pin the blame on intelligence failure. However, their allegation of intelligence failure rings hollow for a couple of reasons. First, they had had enough time and resources at their disposal to collect the requisite tactical intelligence and plan their operation based on it. If a single civilian employee of the SFF could do that job successfully on two previous occasions, the army, with its Intelligence Corps headed by a lieutenant general, had far superior resources at its command. Second, the commanding officer of the SFF had already advised Maj. Gen. Brar against a full frontal assault on the Akal Takht in view of the positioning of the defences. However, it appears that General Sundarji was in an inordinate hurry to prove his mettle in keeping with the promise made by General Vaidya to the prime minister.

Sundarji could have also chosen to follow the Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) laid down by his predecessor Lt Gen. S.K. Sinha. But Sundarji might have wanted the operation to have his personal stamp if he was going to take full credit for it. Also, the casualties would have been far less had the period of operation been carefully chosen. As was the case with the aborted SSF operation, which coincided with Baisakhi celebrations at the Golden Temple, Operation Blue Star was launched on the martyrdom day of Guru